

edence over perfection, and I believe balance exists in your mind and not in your time allocation. As long as there is work-life harmony, I am on the right track.”

Mehta recalls how her husband Asit suggested that she join the stock exchange. She did, in 1985, and found she was the only woman in the trading ring. In those days, long before computerisation, the ring was a raucous place where brokers and jobbers shouted orders in their jargon and unique sign language and jostled for space.

“People in my organisation tried to dissuade me from entering the trading ring. But it became a prestige issue,” she says.

36 | Mehta is an Associate Chartered Accountant (ACA), a Masters in Management Studies in Finance (MMS), and has a diploma in Stock Exchange and Securities Law.

Initially, she enjoyed a lot of respect and care from the male fraternity. All that changed when she decided to stand for election to the post of exchange president.

She says, “Men are comfortable with us as peers, but once you become first among equals, swords are drawn.”

Some people in her organisation didn't want her to take the place of the president, but others were unbiased and appreciated the ideas she had while working in the exchange, and that is how she became the first woman president of the exchange with the highest-ever votes secured by any candidate.

FINANCIAL INDEPENDENCE

A DBS Bank India study, ‘*Women and Finance*’, conducted in partnership with CRISIL, found that 47% of women make financial decisions independently. However, working women tend to be risk-averse



“Change is first required at the family and society level before we talk of any changes at the workplace”

DEVINA MEHRA
Chairperson and MD,
First Global

and park 51% of their investments in fixed deposits and savings accounts, followed by 16% in gold, 15% in mutual funds, 10% in real estate and only 7% in stocks.

Iyer thinks financial independence is non-negotiable for women, and they must take charge of their finances. The best way to do this is financial education.

Mehra says women must educate themselves by signing up for formal courses, reading books or watching videos. Women who depend on others to invest for them must ask questions. “Never think you will look like a fool if you ask for explanations from your advisors or intermediaries,” Mehra says.

Women have a natural edge in investing because of their disciplined approach and risk-averse nature, which can translate into smart, sustainable investment choices.

Priti Rathi Gupta says, “Read, learn, and ask other women about their financial planning journeys; start small, but start with an SIP.” An SIP or systematic investment plan lets you save regularly in a mutual fund.

Data shows that women investors are also slowly making their presence felt in mutual funds. According to the Association of Mutual Funds of India (Amfi), the share of women in industry assets has expanded from 15% in March 2017 to nearly 21% as of December 2023. The pace of growth is more prominent in the hinterland than in urban centres.

Radhika Gupta, CEO and MD of Edelweiss Mutual Fund, says, “More and more young women are taking interest in managing their own money. “Indian women have always been amazing savers. The transformation from saving to investment is happening.”

Gupta, 41, who manages assets worth ₹1.40 lakh crore as of